Northwind Labs

Employee & Engineering Handbook

Version 4.2 | Effective 1 January 2026

Fictional document created for RAG practice. Northwind Labs is not a real company.

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1. Welcome to Northwind Labs

1.1 About the company

Northwind Labs was founded in 2014 and is headquartered in Chennai, with a second office in Bengaluru. About 420 people work here across engineering, product, customer success and operations. Our main product is Northwind Pulse, an observability platform that helps customers monitor event-driven systems such as queues, streams and serverless functions. Most of our customers are fintech and logistics companies running workloads on AWS.

1.2 Our values

- **Own the outcome.** You are responsible for the result, not only for your task. If something is blocked, you unblock it or you escalate it.
- **Write it down.** Decisions, designs and incident timelines live in the team wiki, not in private chats or personal drives.
- **Ship small.** Small changes are easier to review, easier to test and easier to roll back.
- **Be kind in review.** Review the code, not the person. Say what is good as well as what must change.

1.3 How to use this handbook

This is version 4.2 of the handbook, effective 1 January 2026. It is owned by People Operations and applies to all full-time employees. Contractors and interns follow the same security and conduct rules but have separate leave and benefits terms.

Policy changes made between annual editions are published as numbered notices in Appendix A. When a notice conflicts with the body of the handbook, the notice wins. Questions can be sent to people@northwindlabs.example or raised in the #people-help channel.

1.4 Who to ask

For leave, benefits and payroll, contact People Operations. For laptops, software and access, use ServiceHub. For anything involving a suspected security issue, contact the Security team immediately. Contact details are listed in Appendix C.

2. Working Hours and Remote Work

2.1 Standard hours

The standard working week is 40 hours. Core hours are 10:30 to 16:30 IST, Monday to Friday. During this window people are expected to be reachable and to attend meetings. Outside core hours you may arrange your day around personal commitments as long as your team agrees handover times. Meetings should not be scheduled before 10:00 or after 18:00 IST without the consent of the attendees.

2.2 Hybrid and remote roles

Roles marked hybrid on the offer letter work from the office on Tuesday, Wednesday and Thursday. Mondays and Fridays are remote by default. Roles marked fully remote have no office-day requirement, but those employees must be able to travel to Chennai or Bengaluru for the two company offsites each year, which are paid for by the company.

2.3 Working from another city or country

With manager approval, you may work from a different city in India for up to 20 working days in a calendar year.

Working from another country is limited to 10 working days in a calendar year, requires written approval from the Security team, and is not permitted from countries on the restricted list maintained by Security because of data residency and export rules. Employees are responsible for confirming any tax or immigration implications before they travel.

2.4 Home office support

New employees receive a one-time home-office allowance of INR 15,000 for a chair, desk or monitor. The company also reimburses internet costs of up to INR 1,500 per month, on submission of the bill through ExpenseDesk.

2.5 Public holidays and floating holidays

There are 12 public holidays each year. The holiday calendar for the next year is published in December. In addition, every employee gets 2 floating holidays per year, which can be used for festivals or occasions that are not on the official calendar. Floating holidays must be applied for at least 3 working days in advance and cannot be carried forward.

2.6 Availability and time zones

Teams that work with customers in other time zones agree a published overlap window. Nobody is expected to be reachable outside their agreed hours unless they are on call (see Chapter 7). Messages sent outside someone's working hours should not be marked urgent unless there is an active incident.

3. Leave Policy

3.1 Overview

Northwind Labs provides several kinds of leave. Each kind has its own allowance, carry-forward rule and approval path, so check the right section before you apply. All leave is requested in PeopleHub.

3.2 Annual leave

Full-time employees get 24 days of annual leave per calendar year, accruing at 2 days per month. Up to 10 unused days can be carried forward into the next year. Any balance above 10 days lapses on 31 March.

Annual leave cannot be encashed while you are employed. On exit, up to 15 days of unused annual leave are encashed at the basic salary rate. Leave of more than 3 consecutive days should be applied for at least 5 working days in advance.

3.3 Sick leave

Employees get 12 days of paid sick leave per calendar year. Sick leave does not carry forward and cannot be encashed. A medical certificate is required when sick leave covers 3 or more consecutive working days. For planned medical procedures, tell your manager and People Operations as early as you can.

3.4 Casual leave

Casual leave is 8 days per calendar year for short personal matters. No more than 3 consecutive days of casual leave can be taken at once; longer absences should use annual leave. Casual leave does not carry forward.

3.5 Parental leave

Maternity leave is 26 weeks of paid leave for the first two children and 12 weeks for subsequent children, in line with the Maternity Benefit Act. Paternity leave is 10 working days of paid leave and must be taken within 6 months of the child's birth. Adoption leave is 12 weeks for the primary caregiver. Parental leave is separate from annual, sick and casual leave.

3.6 Bereavement leave

On the death of an immediate family member (spouse, child, parent or sibling), employees get 5 working days of paid bereavement leave. For extended family, such as grandparents or parents-in-law, the allowance is 2 working days. Bereavement leave does not reduce other leave balances.

3.7 Sabbatical

After 4 years of continuous service, employees may request an unpaid sabbatical of up to 8 weeks. Requests need approval from the department head and must be made at least 90 days in advance. Health insurance continues during the sabbatical, but any employee-paid share of premiums must still be paid by the employee.

3.8 Approvals

Managers approve or reject leave requests within 2 working days. Leave of more than 10 consecutive days needs department head approval (see Appendix B). An unapproved absence of more than 3 consecutive days is treated as abandonment of service under the code of conduct.

4. Expenses and Reimbursement

4.1 What can be claimed

Reimbursable business expenses include travel to client sites and company events, meals while travelling, cab fares for work done after 21:00 IST, pre-approved software and books, and conference fees approved under the learning budget. Anything not listed here needs written pre-approval from your manager.

4.2 Spending limits

Category	Limit	Notes
Flights	Economy class only	Book at least 7 days ahead where possible
Hotel in Tier-1 cities (Mumbai, Delhi, Bengaluru, Chennai, Hyderabad)	INR 7,500 per night	Taxes included
Hotel in other cities	INR 5,000 per night	Taxes included
Meals while travelling	INR 1,500 per day	Alcohol excluded
Local cab	Actual fare	Receipt or app invoice required
Personal car used for business travel	INR 12 per km	Log book required
Two-wheeler used for business travel	INR 5 per km	Log book required

4.3 Submitting a claim

Submit claims in ExpenseDesk within 30 days of the date of the expense. A receipt or invoice is required for any single item above INR 500. If a receipt is lost, you can file a missing receipt declaration, limited to INR 2,000 per quarter in total.

Once your approver signs off, the amount is paid with the next monthly payroll, on the last working day of the month. Claims submitted after the deadline are rejected unless the department head grants an exception.

4.4 Approval of claims

Approval limits depend on the claim amount and are listed in Appendix B. A claim cannot be approved by the person who submitted it, or by someone who reports to the claimant.

4.5 What is never reimbursed

The following are never reimbursed: alcohol, hotel minibar and in-room entertainment, personal entertainment, traffic fines and parking penalties, airline upgrades, travel insurance beyond the company policy, and expenses for family members who accompany you.

4.6 Corporate cards

Employees who travel more than 6 times a year may be issued a corporate card with a monthly limit of INR 100,000. Card statements must be reconciled in ExpenseDesk by the 5th of the following month. Cards are for business expenses only.

5. Equipment and IT

5.1 Laptops

Every employee receives a laptop on joining. Engineers can choose between a 14-inch MacBook Pro and a ThinkPad X1 Carbon; other roles receive a ThinkPad T-series by default. Laptops are replaced every 36 months, or earlier if the hardware fails and cannot be repaired. A request for an out-of-cycle upgrade needs a business case approved by the department head.

5.2 Peripherals and monitors

A peripherals budget of INR 8,000 per 24 months covers a keyboard, mouse, headset or webcam. Monitors are provided separately: one 27-inch monitor for each office desk and, for remote employees, a monitor funded from the home-office allowance described in Section 2.4.

5.3 Software requests

Request software through ServiceHub. Standard tools such as IDE licences, VaultKey and Slack are pre-approved. Other licences are reviewed by IT and Security within 3 working days. Open-source tools may be installed without approval unless they need elevated privileges.

5.4 Lost or stolen devices

If a company laptop or phone is lost or stolen, report it to security@northwindlabs.example within 2 hours of discovering the loss, and file a police complaint within 24 hours. IT will remotely lock and wipe the device. Employees are not charged for a loss unless it results from negligence, such as leaving a laptop unattended in a vehicle.

5.5 Personal devices

Personal phones may be used for email and chat only after MDM enrolment. Personal laptops may not be used to access production systems or Restricted data.

5.6 Returning equipment

All equipment must be returned within 5 working days of the last working day. Equipment that is not returned is deducted from the final settlement at book value.

6. Information Security

6.1 Passwords and multi-factor authentication

Use VaultKey, the company password manager, for all work credentials. Passwords must be at least 14 characters. Passwords do not need to be rotated on a schedule, but must be changed immediately if compromise is suspected. Multi-factor authentication is mandatory on all systems. Access to production environments additionally requires a FIDO2 hardware security key.

6.2 Data classification

Level	Examples	Handling
Public	Marketing pages, published documentation	No restrictions
Internal	Org charts, internal wiki, roadmaps	Company tools only
Confidential	Customer contracts, financials, source code	Encrypted storage; share only on a need-to-know basis
Restricted	Customer telemetry containing personal data, encryption keys, credentials	Never stored unencrypted on laptops; never placed in chat tools or external AI tools; all access is logged

6.3 Using AI tools

Only AI tools on the approved list in ServiceHub may be used with company data. Do not paste Confidential or Restricted data into any public AI assistant. Code snippets that contain no secrets or customer data may be used with approved coding assistants.

6.4 Secrets in code

Never commit passwords, tokens or keys to a repository. Use the secrets manager. If a secret is exposed in a repository or log, rotate it within 1 hour of discovery and tell the Security team in #sec-incident. Secret scanning runs on every push and blocks merges.

6.5 Phishing

Use the Report Phish button in the mail client to report suspicious emails. If you clicked a link or opened an attachment, report it within 15 minutes and disconnect from the network. There is no penalty for reporting in good faith.

6.6 Security training

All employees complete security awareness training within 30 days of joining and then once every 12 months. Engineers with production access also complete a secure-coding module every year.

7. On-Call and Incident Response

7.1 Rotation

On-call runs in weekly rotations from Monday 10:00 IST to the following Monday 10:00 IST. Each rotation has a primary and a secondary engineer. A team needs at least 6 engineers to run its own rotation, and no engineer should be on call more than 1 week in 4. Swaps are allowed if agreed in the team channel and recorded in the scheduling tool before the shift starts.

7.2 Compensation

On-call engineers receive a standby allowance of INR 3,000 per week as primary or INR 1,500 per week as secondary. An additional INR 1,200 is paid for each out-of-hours incident that takes more than 30 minutes to handle.

If incident work between 00:00 and 06:00 IST totals more than 2 hours, the engineer gets a compensatory day off, to be taken within 14 days.

7.3 Severity levels

Level	Definition	Acknowledge within	Update cadence
SEV1	Complete outage, data loss or security breach affecting customers	5 minutes	Every 30 minutes
SEV2	Major degradation, or a key feature unavailable for many customers	15 minutes	Every hour
SEV3	Minor degradation with a workaround	4 business hours	Daily
SEV4	Cosmetic issue or request with no customer impact	Next sprint planning	None

7.4 Incident roles

For SEV1 and SEV2 incidents, the on-call engineer opens an incident channel and assigns three roles: the Incident Commander, who makes decisions and coordinates; the Communications Lead, who posts customer and executive updates; and the Scribe, who keeps the timeline. The Incident Commander may not also be the person doing the hands-on fix.

7.5 Escalation

If the primary does not acknowledge a page within the window, it escalates automatically to the secondary after 10 minutes and to the engineering manager after 20 minutes. For SEV1, the VP Engineering is notified immediately.

7.6 Postmortems

A blameless postmortem is required for every SEV1 and SEV2 incident. The draft is due within 5 working days of resolution and is reviewed at the weekly Ops Review. Action items need an owner and a due date, and are tracked until closed.

8. Engineering Practices

8.1 Code review

Every change needs at least 1 approving review from a teammate. Changes that touch authentication, payments or access control need 2 approvals, one of them from a member of the Security Champions group. Aim for pull requests under 400 changed lines. Reviewers should respond within 1 working day.

8.2 Branching

We use trunk-based development. Branches should live no longer than 3 days. Long-running feature work is hidden behind feature flags rather than kept on long-lived branches.

8.3 Deployment windows

Production deployments are allowed Monday to Thursday between 10:00 and 16:00 IST. There are no Friday deployments. A change freeze runs from 20 December to 2 January each year; during the freeze only SEV1 fixes may be deployed, with VP Engineering approval.

8.4 Testing standards

New code needs at least 80 percent unit-test coverage. Changes to public APIs require contract tests. Load tests are required before launching any service that is expected to handle more than 1,000 requests per second.

8.5 Feature flags and staged rollouts

Any change that could affect more than 10 percent of customers must ship behind a feature flag and roll out in stages: 1 percent, 10 percent, 50 percent, then 100 percent, with at least 30 minutes of observation at each stage.

8.6 Database migrations

Schema changes must be backwards compatible, using the expand and contract pattern. Add the new column or table first, deploy code that writes to both, backfill the data, switch reads over, and only then remove the old structure in a later release.

8.7 Documentation

Every service has a README with its owner, on-call rotation, dashboards and runbook links. Architecture decisions are recorded as short decision records in the repository and are reviewed like code.

9. Error Code Reference for Northwind Pulse

9.1 Introduction

This chapter lists the error codes returned by the Northwind Pulse ingestion API and what customers and support engineers should do about them. Codes starting with 4 are client errors, codes starting with 5 are service-side errors, codes starting with 7 are account and tenant errors, and codes starting with 9 are licensing errors.

9.2 Error codes

Code	Meaning	Recommended action
ERR-4021	Ingestion payload exceeds the 1 MB limit	Split the batch into smaller requests
ERR-4093	Rate limit exceeded: more than 600 requests per minute per API key	Back off and retry; request a higher limit through Support
ERR-4107	Event timestamp is more than 24 hours in the past	Check the sender's clock, or replay through the backfill endpoint
ERR-5503	Downstream collector unavailable	Retry after 30 seconds; page on-call if it persists for more than 10 minutes
ERR-5507	Schema registry version mismatch	Redeploy the producer with the latest schema
ERR-7710	Tenant storage quota exhausted	Contact the customer's account manager; do not delete data to free space without approval
ERR-7745	Retention policy conflict between tenant and project settings	Align the settings; the tenant setting wins
ERR-9001	Licence expired	Renew through Sales; ingestion stops after a 7-day grace period

9.3 Retry guidance

For rate-limit and service-side errors, clients should retry with exponential backoff starting at 1 second and doubling each time, with random jitter, up to a maximum of 5 retries. Never retry ERR-4021 or ERR-4107 unchanged, because the same request will fail again.

Support engineers should ask for the request ID before investigating. It is returned in the X-Pulse-Request-Id response header.

9.4 Escalation

ERR-5503 and ERR-5507 that affect more than one tenant are treated as SEV2 incidents. ERR-7710 for an enterprise-plan customer should be raised with the account manager within 4 business hours.

10. Performance Reviews and Promotions

10.1 Review cycle

Performance is reviewed twice a year. A mid-year check-in takes place in July and is informal and conversation-based. The formal annual review takes place in January and covers the previous calendar year. Ratings use a 1 to 5 scale, where 3 means meets expectations.

10.2 360-degree feedback

For annual reviews, each employee nominates 4 to 6 peers and the manager approves the list. Feedback is collected in PeopleHub over two weeks and is anonymised before it is shared.

10.3 Salary revisions

Salary revisions take effect on 1 April each year, based on the January review. Revision letters are issued by the end of March.

10.4 Promotions

Promotions are decided twice a year and announced in April and October. Employees must have spent at least 12 months at their current level, and the promotion case must show sustained performance at the next level. Levels run from L1 (associate) to L7 (principal).

10.5 Performance improvement plans

If performance is below expectations, the manager and People Operations may start a Performance Improvement Plan (PIP) lasting 60 days, with written goals and check-ins every two weeks. A PIP is not a disciplinary action, and the employee may bring a colleague to the meetings.

10.6 Disagreeing with a rating

An employee who disagrees with a rating can ask for a calibration review within 10 working days of receiving it. The request goes to People Operations, who arrange a review by a manager from another team.

11. Learning and Development

11.1 Learning budget

Every employee has an annual learning budget of INR 40,000 for courses, certifications, books and conferences. The budget is per calendar year and does not carry over. Claim through ExpenseDesk after completing the programme.

11.2 Certifications

Certification exam fees are reimbursed after the employee passes. If the employee fails, one retake is covered. Cloud provider certifications from AWS, Azure and Google Cloud are pre-approved.

11.3 Conferences

Attending an approved conference counts as working time for up to 3 days. Travel and accommodation follow the limits in Chapter 4 and are charged to the learning budget. Attendees share a written summary in #learning within 2 weeks.

11.4 Learning Fridays

The second Friday afternoon of every month, from 14:00 to 17:30 IST, is protected for learning. No meetings are scheduled in this window.

11.5 Repayment

If an employee leaves within 12 months of a company-funded programme that cost more than INR 25,000, the amount is repayable on a pro-rata basis, based on the number of months not yet completed.

11.6 Buddy programme

Every new joiner is paired with a buddy for the first 90 days. The buddy helps with onboarding, answers day-to-day questions and is not the new joiner's manager.

12. Benefits

12.1 Health insurance

All employees are covered by a group health insurance policy with a sum insured of INR 500,000, covering the employee, spouse and up to 2 children. Parents can be added at the employee's cost. A top-up of INR 500,000 is available at the employee's cost. Coverage starts on the date of joining.

12.2 Life and accident cover

Group term life insurance covers 5 times annual fixed pay. Personal accident cover is INR 1,000,000.

12.3 Provident fund and gratuity

The company contributes 12 percent of basic salary to the provident fund, matched by the employee. Gratuity is payable after 5 years of continuous service, as per the Payment of Gratuity Act.

12.4 Wellness

A wellness allowance of INR 12,000 per year can be claimed for gym memberships, fitness classes or wellness apps. The employee assistance programme offers free, confidential counselling, up to 8 sessions per year per employee, through a 24-hour helpline.

12.5 Meals

Employees at the Chennai and Bengaluru offices have access to a subsidised cafeteria. Employees who are in the office at least 8 days a month also receive a meal card of INR 2,200 per month.

12.6 Referral bonus

Employees who refer a candidate who is hired receive INR 50,000 once the new joiner completes 6 months. The bonus is not payable for roles in the referrer's own reporting line.

12.7 Equity

Equity grants, where applicable, are described in individual offer letters and are not covered in this handbook.

13. Code of Conduct

13.1 Respectful workplace

Harassment, discrimination and bullying are not tolerated, whether in the office, online or at company events. Complaints of sexual harassment are handled by the Internal Committee constituted under the POSH Act.

13.2 Conflicts of interest

Outside employment or paid consulting requires prior written approval from the department head and People Operations. Investments of more than 1 percent in a competitor, customer or supplier must be disclosed.

13.3 Gifts

Gifts from customers or suppliers worth more than INR 5,000 must be declared to People Operations within 7 days. Cash or cash equivalents must always be refused.

13.4 Reporting concerns

Raise concerns with your manager, with People Operations, or anonymously through the ethics hotline at ethics@northwindlabs.example or the hotline number in Appendix C. Retaliation against anyone who reports in good faith is a disciplinary offence.

13.5 Investigations

Reports are acknowledged within 3 working days. Investigations are normally concluded within 60 days, and both parties are informed of the outcome.

13.6 Social media and public statements

Employees may share their own views online but must not speak on behalf of Northwind Labs unless authorised by Communications, and must never disclose Confidential or Restricted information.

14. Offboarding

14.1 Notice period

The notice period is 60 days for levels L1 to L4 and 90 days for L5 and above. During the probation period (the first 6 months) the notice period is 30 days. Notice can be shortened by mutual agreement. A buyout of unserved notice requires approval from the department head and is paid at gross monthly pay on a pro-rata basis.

14.2 Knowledge transfer

Within the first week of the notice period, the employee and manager agree a knowledge-transfer plan. Documentation must be in the team wiki, not in personal drives.

14.3 Access and equipment

System access is revoked at 18:00 IST on the last working day. Equipment returns follow Section 5.6.

14.4 Final settlement

The full and final settlement, including leave encashment under Section 3.2, is paid within 45 days of the last working day. The experience letter and relieving letter are issued within 10 working days, provided the clearance process is complete.

14.5 Rehire

Former employees who left in good standing are eligible for rehire after 6 months. Prior service counts towards leave and gratuity only if the break in service is less than 90 days.

Appendix A: Policy Change Notices

The notices below were issued after version 4.2 of the handbook took effect. Where a notice conflicts with the body of the handbook, the notice applies.

Notice 2026-03 (effective 1 July 2026): expense claim window

The claim submission window in Section 4.3 is extended from 30 days to 45 days from the date of the expense. The INR 500 receipt threshold is unchanged.

Notice 2026-05 (effective 1 August 2026): on-call allowance

The primary on-call standby allowance in Section 7.2 increases from INR 3,000 to INR 3,500 per week. The secondary allowance and the INR 1,200 per-incident payment are unchanged.

Notice 2026-07 (effective 1 September 2026): Learning Fridays

Learning Fridays in Section 11.4 now take place on the second and fourth Friday of every month, from 14:00 to 17:30 IST.

Appendix B: Approval Matrix

This table lists who approves what. Where a request falls into more than one row, the stricter approver applies.

Item	Amount or condition	Approver
Expense claim	Up to INR 10,000	Reporting manager
Expense claim	INR 10,001 to INR 50,000	Department head
Expense claim	INR 50,001 to INR 200,000	VP Finance
Expense claim	Above INR 200,000	CFO
Leave	More than 10 consecutive days	Department head
Equipment purchase	Above INR 100,000	Head of IT and VP Finance
Vendor contract	Above INR 500,000	VP Finance and Legal
Change freeze exception	Any SEV1 fix during the freeze	VP Engineering

Appendix C: Contacts

Team	Contact	Channel
People Operations	people@northwindlabs.example	#people-help
Security	security@northwindlabs.example	#sec-incident
IT support	ServiceHub portal, extension 4000	#it-help
Payroll	payroll@northwindlabs.example	#payroll
Ethics hotline	ethics@northwindlabs.example, +91 44 5550 0100 (24 hours)	Anonymous reporting available